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Luis Arrese (E): Ana's Version

Francisco Gay
Alberto Ribera
José Ramón Pin Arboledas

The following text is a summary of conversations held with Luis's wife, Ana.

What Happened in July 2018? What Was Luis's Experience of That Situation? What Was Your Experience?

It came as a complete shock to Luis, it was like a stab in the back. His managers had not been truthful. With the promises that had been made to him, he never doubted that his expectations would be fulfilled. For Luis, the basic principle that all others rested upon was: "truth first."

When they told him that they had to go back on what they had said, he felt betrayed. It was that fact that was too much for him, overwhelming him more than the financial aspect or the job's social status.

He became very bad-tempered. He was irritable, even at home with the children, although he knew that he had to calm down and not let his anger take over.

I was stuck in the middle, since I couldn't explain a situation to the children that they were not going to understand. All I could do was listen, try and calm him down and help him not be carried away by impulsiveness and anger. I knew that when he calmed down, he would think it over and view things in a better light. I couldn't do anything more than be there and listen.

This case was prepared by Francisco Gay, former collaborator, and Dr. Alberto Ribera, under the supervision of Professor José Ramón Pin Arboledas. February 2023.
This case is based on the case "Luis Arrese (E): Ana's version," DPO-112-E, by the same authors.
IESE cases are designed to promote class discussion rather than to illustrate effective or ineffective management of a given situation.

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What Happened Afterwards

Shortly after, perhaps less than two weeks later, he started to think about what he could do. He calmed down enough to think and look forward, without dwelling on the recent and not so recent past. But it wasn't until he started to think about a new project that I saw an improvement.

On one level, the crisis didn't last very long. But on another level, it's still going on because he's no longer the person he used to be; he has not been able to shake off the feeling of betrayal.

It contrasts with his great generosity and concern for people. For example, during the time in Italy, he was very unhappy during the staff cuts and did all he could to make sure that the redundancies were made in the best possible manner for the employees. I have also had the chance to meet his secretaries, in Valencia, England and the United States. All three expressed appreciation told me that they had never had a boss who treated them so well. One of them told me that Luis made her feel that she was much better than she really was, capable of performing tasks that she had not considered until then or she had not been given the opportunity to perform. They realize that he is demanding but appreciate his honesty and sincerity.

What Is Luis Like? What Features Would You Highlight of His Temperament, Those Aspects That Most Seem to Express His Personality?

He has always been someone who knew what he wants and is convinced that he can put all his efforts in achieving this goal. He's not arrogant. When he realized that he has gone too far, he steps back and asks for forgiveness, even to his 12-year-old son. And I know he does the same at work. If he overreacts, he apologizes. He secretaries tell me this.

We married young. One year earlier—when we had been going out for a few months—I decided to leave the firm I was working for to start my own business, encouraged by Luis and with the money he lent me. We started the business before we were married. It surprised me that—although we had not been going out together for very long—he did all this for me. With him, everything goes very quickly.

One question he asked me particularly struck me, "What do you want to be when you're 40?" I had never asked myself that question so I asked him the same question back, "And what do you want to be?" The confidence of his answer impressed me even more: "By the time I'm 40, I'll be CEO of a large company with a family of four or five children."

How Has Luis's Professional Life Affected Your Family, Your Ambitions and Your Own Career?

As far as my own work is concerned, it was Luis who encouraged me and introduced me to the right people in order to set up my own business. Since then, I've had the good fortune to work at something I enjoy and to arrange my own timetable.

In London, I learned English and worked as a volunteer in a charity shop. Then, one day, he came home and said, "We've been bought and the new owner is going to appoint a new CEO. We're leaving."

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When we came back to Valencia, he considered the possibility of working on growing my business. He thought about it, but I never took that possibility seriously. I would not have accepted it. I couldn't have him beside me all day.

But Not Long After, There Was the Transfer to the States …

The new job in Valencia, when he returned from England, bored him. "I have no challenges. I've done all my work by 10 in the morning," he used to say. He spoke to Marc, stating his concerns, saying in no uncertain terms that if he wasn't offered something different, he would look for another job and they proposed that he move to America.

I supported his decision to go to the States. He said to me, "If you say no, I'll say no and look for another job." He said it sincerely. But neither of us would have been happy. I knew that he had the ability to become CEO in his company and it didn't seem fair to me to stop him from doing this. I also saw in Luis's going an opportunity for me to go there every two or three months, to get to know another country with a different outlook, from which I would gain a lot.

But neither of us were conscious of how this long-distance period would be. It was difficult, very difficult.

We were both in agreement that Luis should take the decision about accepting the move. When they asked him to stay in America until June, he again asked me whether he should accept it or whether he should turn them down and look for another job.

But Hasn't Luis's Career Come at a Cost to the Family?

It is true that the children are not as open with their father as they are with me. But that perhaps has more to do with Luis's character than whether or not he is at home. The children admire their father enormously. Sometimes they fear him a little, because of the state he gets into when he's angry, but they are very fond of him. When he's at home, especially at weekends, he spends a lot of time with them. He's demanding with them. His way of talking is: "I can't believe that I have to tell you time and time again to brush your teeth." He cannot understand that saying something just once is not enough because he would never have dreamed of not doing something that his father had told him to do.

As for me, I have the security of knowing I can count on him, and I don't think this comes from spending every day together but rather it's to do with the way he always is with me.

I don't think that Luis would be a better father spending more time at home. He isn't cut out for household affairs and routine tasks and he doesn't know how to deal with them. He can't stay still, without doing anything. He sees leisure as changing activities.

But for me, living with someone like Luis and having a marriage in which we have an excellent relationship and share a common commitment does not mean having to be together every day.

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Lastly, Is There Anything in the Case Study That You Don't Agree With and Which You Would Like to Clarify or Change?

Yes, because the case study doesn't portray me as I see myself. It seems to put me across as a person who meekly accepts her fate. That's not the way it is. He wouldn't have wanted that either. I have never seen myself as a victim. I have never been a "Cinderella" type of person.

For him, his career is important, almost vital, but if he'd been put between a rock and a hard place—your family or your career—I doubt if he'd have chosen his career. We've never found ourselves in that situation because I've always supported him, and I've done so because I thought it was good for him and good for me.

Living with Luis is enormously enriching. It still is after many years together. It's a life in which never stop surprising each other. Sometimes, he amazes me with the things he says and thinks. I couldn't be with anyone who had no depth, who didn't nourish me. There is one thing in which we are both very similar: we both want to learn.

For my own part, I know that, had I not met Luis, I certainly wouldn't have had many of the experiences I've had. It's been very enriching. Luis and I are from very different backgrounds. I had to go out to work when I was very young, and I don't have a university education like him, nor did I have any financial support. Luis has always helped me a lot to feel appreciated, as a person and also in my career. I think that I have gained a lot from being with him, I have received a lot from him … and the case study I have read seems to suggest the opposite.